She Always Thought She Was a Citizen. Now She Faces a Voting Charge

From: PBS NewsHour Mined: 2026-10-25 3 min read

Marva Cook always believed she was an American citizen. Now, at 66, she has learned otherwise, and she has been charged with voting illegally.

Cook lives in Syracuse, New York, and was **adopted** as a toddler. She told Homeland Security investigators earlier this month that she had always assumed she was born in the United States. But while searching for her **biological** mother, she said, she discovered she had a German birth certificate.

Federal **prosecutors** say Cook has held a **green card** for several years. They say she still cast ballots in recent elections even though she was not a citizen. She faces a single federal charge of voting by a noncitizen, tied to her vote in the 2022 midterm elections. She turned herself in and appeared in court on Wednesday. She declined to discuss the case, but said the court appearance was difficult and thanked the community members who came to court with her.

The case is one of the latest arrests highlighted by the Trump administration as it searches for noncitizen voters ahead of the midterms. Its own investigations, though, have shown such cases are incredibly rare and have not changed election outcomes.

Cook's supporters describe her very differently. She starred on Syracuse University's women's basketball team decades ago, leading the team in scoring in 1979-80 with 15 points per game, and she holds the school record for steals in a single season. Today she works as the YMCA's community school program director, supporting low-income families and young people. Her pastor, Fred Daley, said she is an active church member who for years dressed up as the church's Easter Bunny, and a longtime **parishioner** called her a person of service.

Word Treasure

adopted -- Taken in and raised as part of a new family when you are a child.

biological -- Related by birth, such as a birth mother or birth father.

green card -- A document that lets a person from another country live and work in the United States.

prosecutors -- Lawyers who bring a criminal case against someone in court.

parishioner -- A regular member of a local church community.

Background you need

In the United States, only citizens are allowed to vote in federal elections.

A green card lets a person live and work in the country, but it does not make that person a citizen.

A person's birth certificate and adoption papers can decide what citizenship they hold, and sometimes grown-ups only learn the answer much later in life.

Break it down

WHO: Marva Cook, federal prosecutors, and Cook's supporters.
WHAT: Cook was charged with voting illegally after learning she was not a citizen.
WHERE: Syracuse, New York.
WHY: Because prosecutors say she cast ballots even though she was not a citizen.

Why it matters

It shows why it matters to check important papers and rules carefully, even when you think you already know the answer.

Test what you remember

1. What did Marva Cook always believe about herself?

- (A) That she was born in Germany
- (B) That she had never voted
- (C) That she lived in Canada
- (D) That she was an American citizen

2. What did Cook discover while searching for her biological mother?

- (A) A German birth certificate
- (B) A map of New York
- (C) A letter from her school
- (D) An old basketball trophy

3. What do federal prosecutors say about Cook?

- (A) She worked for the government
- (B) She held a green card for several years and still cast ballots even though she was not a citizen
- (C) She was born in Syracuse
- (D) She never voted in any election

4. What charge does Cook face?

- (A) A charge of moving to another state
- (B) A charge of running for office
- (C) A charge of stealing votes
- (D) A single federal charge of voting by a noncitizen, tied to her vote in the 2022 midterm elections

5. What have investigations shown about cases like this one?

- (A) They are incredibly rare and have not changed election outcomes
- (B) They are very common and change election outcomes
- (C) They happen in every town
- (D) They have never been studied

6. What does Cook do today?

- (A) She coaches a college team
- (B) She works as the YMCA's community school program director, supporting low-income families and young people
- (C) She teaches driving lessons
- (D) She runs a bakery

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: D 2: A 3: B 4: D 5: A 6: B

Questions to think about

1. Federal prosecutors: They say Cook held a green card and still cast ballots even though she was not a citizen.

2. The Trump administration: It is highlighting arrests like this one as it searches for noncitizen voters ahead of the midterms.

3. Cook's supporters: They describe her as a person of service who supports low-income families and young people.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):